Contents

I Preliminaries

1 Foundations of Machine Learning . . . 17

1.1 Math Basics . . . 18

1.1.1 Linear Algebra . . . 18

1.1.2 Probability and Statistics . . . 22

1.2 Designing a Text Classifier . . . 25

1.2.1 Problem Formulation . . . 26

1.2.2 Documents as Feature Vectors . . . 28

1.2.3 Linear Classifiers . . . 29

1.2.4 Generative vs Discriminative . . . 30

1.2.5 OOV Words and Smoothing . . . 34

1.3 General Problems . . . 36

1.3.1 Supervised and Unsupervised Models . . . 36

1.3.2 Inductive Bias . . . 37

1.3.3 Non-linearity . . . 39

1.3.4 Training and Loss Functions . . . 41

1.3.5 Overfitting and Underfitting . . . 46

1.3.6 Prediction and Inference . . . 48

1.4 Model Selection and Evaluation . . . 49

1.4.1 Strategies for Model Selection . . . 50

1.4.2 Training, Validation and Test Data . . . 55

1.4.3 Performance Measure . . . 56

1.4.4 Significance Tests . . . 56

1.5 NLP Tasks as ML Tasks . . . 58

1.5.1 Classification . . . 58

1.5.2 Sequence Labeling . . . 59

1.5.3 Language Modeling/Word Prediction . . . 60

1.5.4 Sequence Generation . . . 61

1.5.5 Tree Generation . . . 62

1.5.6 Relevance Modeling . . . 64

1.5.7 Linguistic Alignment . . . 65
1.5.8 Information Extraction . . . 66
1.5.9 Remarks . . . 67
1.6 Summary . . . 67

2 Foundations of Neural Networks . . . 69
2.1 Multi-layer Neural Networks . . . 69
2.1.1 Single-layer Perceptrons . . . 69
2.1.2 Stacking Multiple Layers . . . 71
2.1.3 Computation Graphs . . . 73
2.2 Example: Neural Language Modeling . . . 76
2.3 Basic Model Architectures . . . 81
2.3.1 Recurrent Units . . . 81
2.3.2 Convolutional Units . . . 83
2.3.3 Gate Units . . . 86
2.3.4 Normalization (Standardization) Units . . . 86
2.3.5 Residual Units . . . 87
2.4 Training Neural Networks . . . 88
2.4.1 Gradient Descent . . . 89
2.4.2 Batching . . . 93
2.4.3 Parameter Initialization . . . 94
2.4.4 Learning Rate Scheduling . . . 95
2.5 Regularization Methods . . . 98
2.5.1 Norm-based Penalties . . . 98
2.5.2 Dropout . . . 99
2.5.3 Early Stopping . . . 101
2.5.4 Smoothing Output Probabilities . . . 102
2.5.5 Training with Noise . . . 104
2.6 Unsupervised Methods and Auto-encoders . . . 106
2.6.1 Auto-encoders with Explicit Regularizers . . . 109
2.6.2 Denoising Auto-encoders . . . 112
2.6.3 Variational Auto-encoders . . . 114
2.7 Summary . . . 118

II Basic Models

3 Words and Word Vectors . . . 121
3.1 Tokenization . . . 121
3.1.1 Tokenization via Rules and Heuristics . . . 122
3.1.2 Tokenization as Language Modeling . . . 124

3.1.3 Tokenization as Sequence Labeling . . . 127
3.1.4 Learning Subwords . . . 128
3.2 Vector Representation for Words . . . 135
3.2.1 One-hot Representation . . . 135
3.2.2 Distributed Representation . . . 136
3.2.3 Compositionality and Contextuality . . . 138
3.3 Count-based Models . . . 140
3.3.1 Co-occurrence Matrices . . . 140
3.3.2 TF-IDF . . . 143
3.3.3 Low-Dimensional Models . . . 144
3.4 Inducing Word Embeddings from NLMs . . . 150
3.5 Word Embedding Models . . . 152
3.5.1 Word2Vec . . . 152
3.5.2 GloVe . . . 154
3.5.3 Remarks . . . 158
3.6 Evaluating Word Embeddings . . . 160
3.6.1 Extrinsic Evaluation . . . 161
3.6.2 Intrinsic Evaluation . . . 161
3.6.3 Visualization . . . 165
3.7 Summary . . . 165

4 Recurrent and Convolutional Sequence Models . . . 169
4.1 Problem Statement . . . 170
4.2 Recurrent Models . . . 171
4.2.1 RNN-based Language Models . . . 171
4.2.2 Training . . . 173
4.2.3 Layer Stacking . . . 176
4.2.4 Bi-directional Models . . . 178
4.3 Memory . . . 179
4.3.1 Memory as A System . . . 180
4.3.2 Long Short-Term Memory . . . 181
4.3.3 Gated Recurrent Units . . . 183
4.4 Convolutional Models . . . 185
4.4.1 Convolution . . . 185
4.4.2 CNNs for Sequence Modeling . . . 189
4.4.3 Handling Positional Information . . . 191
4.5 Examples . . . 196
4.5.1 Text Classification . . . 196
4.5.2 End-to-End Speech Recognition . . . 198
4.5.3 Sequence Labeling with LSTM and Graphical Models . . . 201

4.5.4 Hybrid Models for Language Modeling . . . 205
4.6 Summary . . . 207

5 Sequence-to-Sequence Models . . . 209
5.1 Sequence-to-Sequence Problems . . . 210
5.2 The Encoder-Decoder Architecture . . . 211
5.2.1 Encoding and Decoding . . . 211
5.2.2 Example: Neural Machine Translation . . . 213
5.3 The Attention Mechanism . . . 216
5.3.1 A Basic Model . . . 216
5.3.2 The QKV Attention . . . 221
5.3.3 Multi-head Attention . . . 224
5.3.4 Multi-layer Attention . . . 227
5.3.5 Remarks . . . 228
5.4 Search . . . 233
5.4.1 The Length Problem . . . 234
5.4.2 Pruning and Beam Search . . . 238
5.4.3 Online Search . . . 246
5.4.4 Exact Search . . . 248
5.4.5 Differentiable Search . . . 252
5.4.6 Hypothesis Diversity . . . 254
5.4.7 Combining Multiple Models . . . 256
5.4.8 More Search Objectives . . . 257
5.5 Summary . . . 261

6 Transformers . . . 263
6.1 The Basic Model . . . 263
6.1.1 The Transformer Architecture . . . 263
6.1.2 Positional Encoding . . . 267
6.1.3 Multi-head Self-attention . . . 268
6.1.4 Layer Normalization . . . 270
6.1.5 Feed-forward Neural Networks . . . 271
6.1.6 Decoder-side Attention . . . 272
6.1.7 Training and Inference . . . 275
6.2 Syntax-aware Models . . . 277
6.2.1 Syntax-aware Input and Output . . . 278
6.2.2 Syntax-aware Attention Models . . . 279
6.2.3 Multi-branch Models . . . 281
6.2.4 Multi-scale Models . . . 284
6.2.5 Transformers as Syntax Learners . . . 285

6.3 Improved Architectures . . . 289
6.3.1 Locally Attentive Models . . . 289
6.3.2 Deep Models . . . 293
6.3.3 Numerical Method-Inspired Models . . . 299
6.3.4 Wide Models . . . 302
6.4 Efficient Models . . . 305
6.4.1 Sparse Attention . . . 306
6.4.2 Recurrent and Memory Models . . . 311
6.4.3 Low-dimensional Models . . . 315
6.4.4 Parameter and Activation Sharing . . . 320
6.4.5 Alternatives to Self-Attention . . . 322
6.4.6 Conditional Computation . . . 329
6.4.7 Model Transfer and Pruning . . . 334
6.4.8 Sequence Compression . . . 336
6.4.9 High Performance Computing Methods . . . 338
6.5 Applications . . . 341
6.5.1 Language Modeling . . . 341
6.5.2 Text Encoding . . . 342
6.5.3 Speech Translation . . . 344
6.5.4 Vision Models . . . 347
6.5.5 Multimodal Models . . . 348
6.6 Summary . . . 349

III Large Language Models

7 Pre-training . . . 359
7.1 Pre-training in NLP . . . 360
7.1.1 Unsupervised, Supervised and Self-supervised Pre-training . . . 360
7.1.2 Adapting Pre-trained Models . . . 362
7.2 Self-supervised Pre-training Tasks . . . 365
7.2.1 Decoder-only Pre-training . . . 366
7.2.2 Encoder-only Pre-training . . . 367
7.2.3 Encoder-Decoder Pre-training . . . 374
7.2.4 Comparison of Pre-training Tasks . . . 380
7.3 Example: BERT . . . 382
7.3.1 The Standard Model . . . 382
7.3.2 More Training and Larger Models . . . 387
7.3.3 More Efficient Models . . . 387
7.3.4 Multilingual Models . . . 388

7.4 Applying BERT Models . . . 390
7.5 Summary . . . 396

8 Generative Models . . . 397
8.1 A Brief Introduction to LLMs . . . 398
8.1.1 Decoder-only Transformers . . . 399
8.1.2 Training LLMs . . . 402
8.1.3 Fine-tuning and Applying LLMs . . . 403
8.1.4 Aligning LLMs with the World . . . 409
8.1.5 Prompting LLMs . . . 414
8.2 Training at Scale . . . 419
8.2.1 Data Preparation . . . 419
8.2.2 Model Modifications . . . 421
8.2.3 Distributed Training . . . 424
8.2.4 Scaling Laws . . . 427
8.3 Long Sequence Modeling . . . 430
8.3.1 Hardware and Parallel Computing Optimizations . . . 431
8.3.2 Efficient Architectures . . . 433
8.3.3 Cache and Memory . . . 435
8.3.4 Sharing across Heads and Layers . . . 445
8.3.5 Position Extrapolation and Interpolation . . . 447
8.3.6 Remarks . . . 458
8.4 Summary . . . 460

9 Prompting . . . 463
9.1 General Prompt Design . . . 464
9.1.1 Basics . . . 464
9.1.2 In-context Learning . . . 467
9.1.3 Prompt Engineering Strategies . . . 469
9.1.4 More Examples . . . 474
9.2 Advanced Prompting Methods . . . 484
9.2.1 Chain of Thought . . . 484
9.2.2 Problem Decomposition . . . 487
9.2.3 Self-refinement . . . 494
9.2.4 Ensembling . . . 500
9.2.5 RAG and Tool Use . . . 504
9.3 Learning to Prompt . . . 509
9.3.1 Prompt Optimization . . . 510
9.3.2 Soft Prompts . . . 513
9.3.3 Prompt Length Reduction . . . 524
9.4 Summary . . . 525

10 Alignment . . . 527
10.1 Overview of LLM Alignment . . . 528
10.2 Instruction Alignment . . . 529
10.2.1 Supervised Fine-tuning . . . 530
10.2.2 Fine-tuning Data Construction . . . 535
10.2.3 Fine-tuning with Less Data . . . 540
10.2.4 Instruction Generalization . . . 541
10.2.5 Weak-to-Strong Generalization . . . 543
10.3 Human Preference Alignment: RLHF . . . 547
10.3.1 Basics of Reinforcement Learning . . . 547
10.3.2 Training Reward Models . . . 554
10.3.3 Training LLMs . . . 557
10.4 Improved Human Preference Alignment . . . 562
10.4.1 Better Reward Modeling . . . 562
10.4.2 Direct Preference Optimization . . . 569
10.4.3 Automatic Preference Data Generation . . . 572
10.4.4 Step-by-step Alignment . . . 574
10.4.5 Inference-time Alignment . . . 577
10.5 Summary . . . 578

11 Inference . . . 581
11.1 Prefilling and Decoding . . . 582
11.1.1 Preliminaries . . . 582
11.1.2 A Two-phase Framework . . . 587
11.1.3 Decoding Algorithms . . . 590
11.1.4 Evaluation Metrics for LLM Inference . . . 600
11.2 Efficient Inference Techniques . . . 601
11.2.1 Prefix Caching . . . 602
11.2.2 Batching . . . 603
11.2.3 Parallelization . . . 612
11.2.4 Remarks . . . 613
11.3 Inference-time Scaling . . . 614
11.3.1 Context Scaling . . . 615
11.3.2 Search Scaling . . . 616
11.3.3 Output Ensembling . . . 617
11.3.4 Thinking-Path Generation and Verification . . . 618
11.4 Summary . . . 626

12 Reasoning . . . 629
12.1 Background and Concepts . . . 629
12.1.1 What is Reasoning? . . . 629

12.1.2 Why Reasoning Matters 631
12.1.3 From LLMs to Reasoning Models 632
12.2 Reasoning via Prompting 633
12.3 Inference-time Reasoning 634
12.3.1 Inference-Time Compute Scaling 634
12.3.2 Sampling Multiple Reasoning Paths 636
12.3.3 Search Strategies for Reasoning 639
12.3.4 Verification 640
12.4 Learning to Reason 644
12.4.1 Supervised Reasoning Data 645
12.4.2 Process Supervision 646
12.4.3 On-Policy Distillation for Reasoning 650
12.4.4 Scaling Training for Reasoning 653
12.5 Evaluating Reasoning LLMs 654
12.5.1 Outcome-based vs. Process-based Evaluation 654
12.5.2 Evaluation Metrics 655
12.5.3 Open Issues 657
12.6 Remarks 657
12.6.1 External Reasoning vs. Internal Reasoning 658
12.6.2 Memorization vs. Reasoning 659
12.6.3 Can LLMs Truly Reason? 661
12.7 Summary 662